🍄 mario-decisions-agent

An AI that plays Super Mario Bros by *looking* at the screen — one screenshot at a time.

No memory hacks. No hidden game state. Pixels in, button out.





An AI model playing World 1-1 from raw screenshots — slowed down so you can watch.

The real model is the OpenAI Decisions API (`gpt-6-luna`); reproducing these runs needs your own API key.

What is this?

Most bots that play games cheat a little. They read the game's memory to find out exactly where Mario is, how fast he's moving, and what's coming next — then choose a button. **This one can't do any of that.** It sees what you'd see in a screenshot: one frozen picture of the level. Its entire brain is a remote vision model on the other end of the OpenAI **Decisions API**, and the only thing it is ever asked is:

> *"Here's a picture of the screen. Which move gets me further?"*

That limitation is the whole point, because it turns the project into a clean, honest test of a genuinely open question:

> **How well can a modern vision model play a real-time game when it can only look at still pictures and reply a few times per second?**

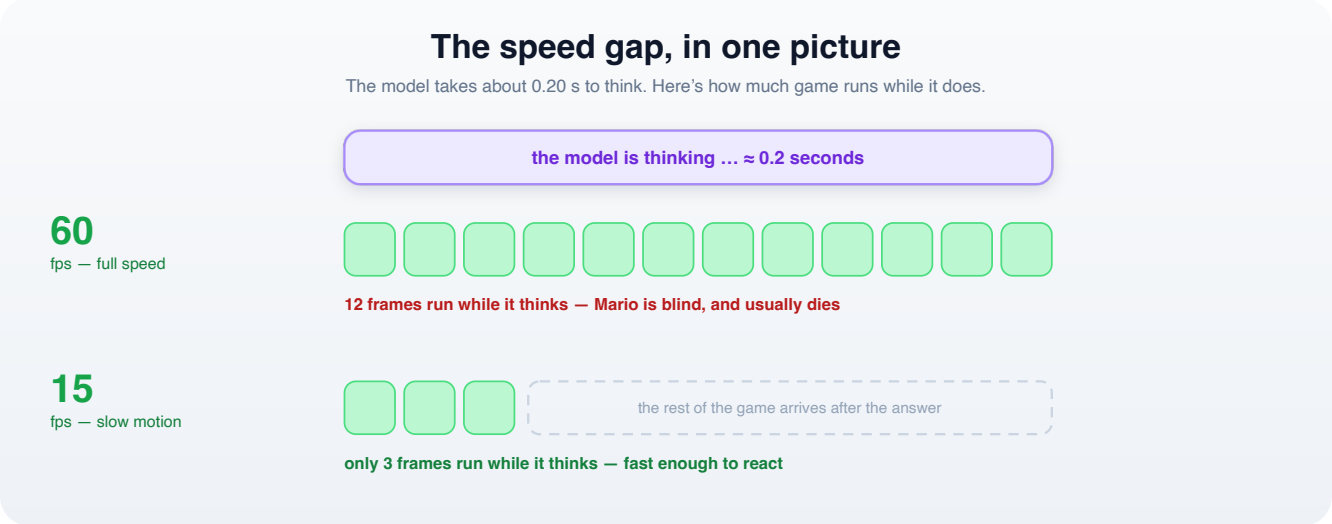
The short answer: surprisingly well. The *interesting* answer is where it breaks — and why. Super Mario Bros updates its world **60 times every second**. The model can only answer about **5 times per second**. Closing that gap is what this repo is about.

The problem: two clocks that don't agree

Imagine playing Mario, but with a twist: after every move you have to phone a very smart friend, describe the screen, and wait for them to tell you what to do next. You can only react as fast as they answer.

- The **game** never waits. It advances 60 steps every second.
- The **model** takes about **0.2 seconds** to reply — so at best it gets to decide about **5 times a second**.

While the model is thinking, Mario keeps running. Get the timing wrong and he walks straight into a Goomba. Managing that timing — *without* secretly feeding the model extra information — is the entire project.



How well does it actually do?

Measured, not guessed. The model's steady reply time is **~0.20 s**, and everything here comes down to one clash: the game advances **60 frames a second**, the model answers about **5 times a second**.

We ran the same match at three game speeds — **15, 30 and 60 fps** — holding everything else fixed (each move covers **8 game frames**), twice each:

Game speed	Reply time	Game frames each move really covers	Decisions	Distance	Watch
15 fps	0.19 s	**8**	36	**722**	▶
30 fps	0.16 s	**8**	36	**722**	▶
60 fps	0.20 s	**12**	40	**722**	▶

Here's what we found:

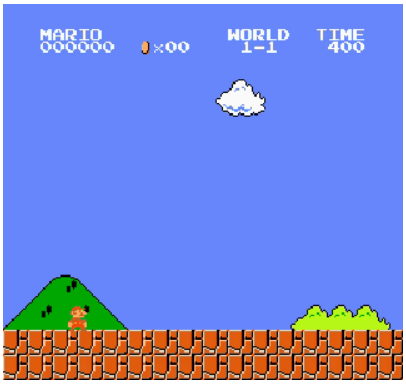
- **At 15 and 30 fps, slowing the game down changes only the clock — not the game.** The model answers faster than each move lasts, so it plays the *exact same* game both times: same decisions, same frames, just stretched over 19.8 s instead of 10.0 s. Slow motion is a viewing trick, not a difficulty setting.
- **At 60 fps, the model can't keep up.** Its answer arrives about **12 frames** after the question, so every move gets held roughly twice as long. The game keeps moving while the model is still thinking — that's the speed gap, and it shows up as stalling.
- **On World 1-1, it doesn't cost a life either way.** All three runs get to the same spot, because 1-1 is the most-copied level in gaming and a model that already knows it can hide bad timing. So this is a claim about **timing**, not about score.

It all comes down to one line:

```
game frames each move really covers  =  max( frames_per_decision ,  latency × game_fps )
```

As long as the model answers before a move ends, the next answer is already waiting when the move finishes. Once `latency × game_fps` gets bigger than `frames_per_decision`, the model starts falling behind.

Watch the three runs

15 fps	30 fps	60 fps
		

The 15 and 30 fps clips are the *same game* at two speeds — the model makes the same moves on the same frames, just played slower. The 60 fps clip is where it starts lagging behind the action.

Try it in 60 seconds

The emulator, the game loop, and an offline stand-in "brain" all run locally — **no API key, no network, no ROM download**:

```
git clone https://github.com/parjanyaacoder/mario-decisions-agent
cd mario-decisions-agent
uv venv --python 3.12
source .venv/bin/activate                # Windows: .venv\Scripts\activate
uv pip install -e ".[mario,record]"

python -m mda --env mario --backend mock --render --scale 3 --fps 30 --frames-per-decision 8
```

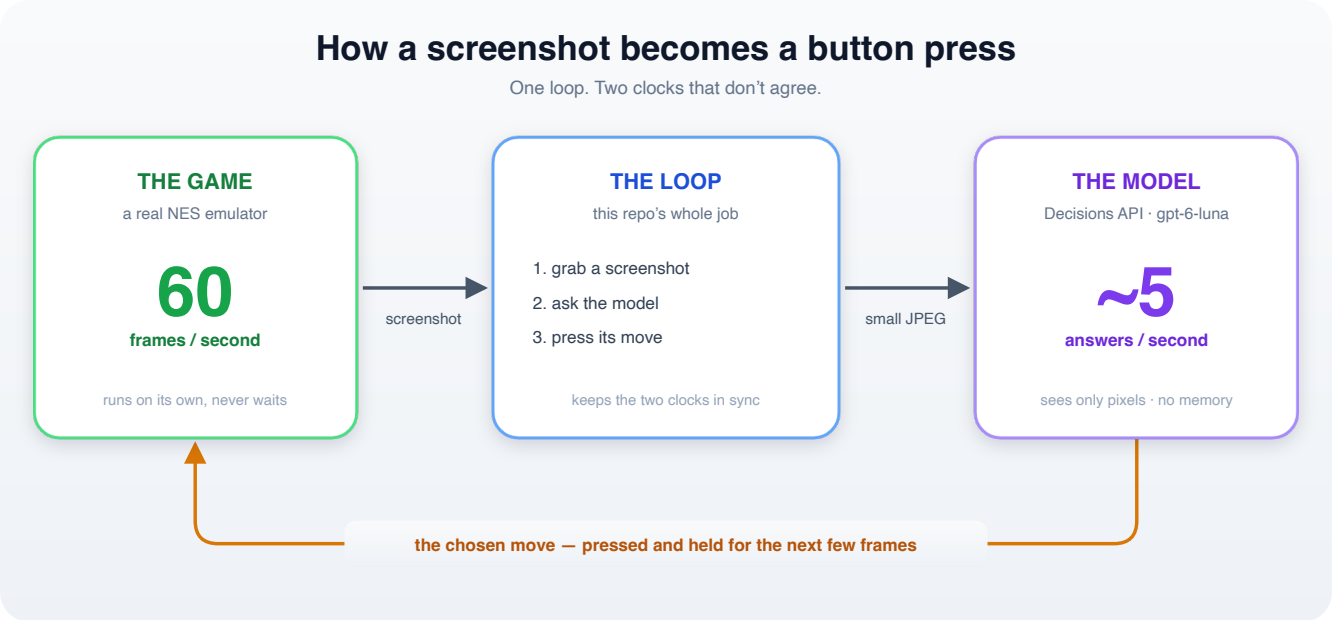
A window opens and a simple offline heuristic plays the game using the *exact same loop* the real model uses.

> **Every number and clip in this README comes from the real model, and reproducing them needs your own OpenAI API key.** The offline `--backend mock` path runs the whole thing for free, but only `--backend live` with `OPENAI_API_KEY` set talks to the actual Decisions API (`gpt-6-luna`). See Using the real model.

How it works

Three pieces, cleanly separated — and each one swappable, which is why the whole thing can run offline:

- **The world** — a real NES emulator stepping the game 60 times a second.
- **The brain** — a remote model that sees one small JPEG and returns one move.
- **The loop** — the glue that keeps a 60 Hz world and a ~5 Hz brain in sync.



One decision, end to end:

1. The emulator advances **one frame** and hands back an RGB picture.
2. The loop shrinks it to a small JPEG and asks the model two things: *which move next?* and *is a hazard coming up?*
3. The model answers with one of **10 sensible moves** — run right, short hop, high jump, wait, back up, and so on — instead of raw button mashing.
4. The loop presses that move and lets it play out for a few frames — while the *next* question is already on its way to the model.

Project layout

```
mario-decisions-agent/
├── src/mda/
│   ├── __main__.py     command-line interface
│   ├── loop.py         blocking + pipelined game loops, frame pacing
│   ├── env.py          MockEnv (offline toy platformer) + MarioEnv (real NES, lazy import)
│   ├── backends.py     MockBackend (offline heuristic) + LiveBackend (/v1/decisions)
│   ├── actions.py      10-move macro menu (held + tapped buttons, per-frame masks)
│   ├── cache.py        trick E: perceptual-hash frame cache
│   ├── viewer.py       resizeable, pixel-crisp game window
│   ├── video.py        headless MP4 / GIF / PNG recording
│   ├── hud.py          on-screen HUD (fps, latency, chosen move, cost)
│   └── recorder.py     JSONL run log
├── scripts/
│   ├── probe_latency.py       measure the model's real reply time — run this first
│   ├── make_preview_gifs.py   turn recorded runs into the clips in docs/media
│   └── make_readme_pdf.py     render this README to a PDF (needs Chrome)
├── tests/
│   └── test_pipeline.py       17 offline tests: no key, no ROM, no network
├── docs/
│   ├── architecture.svg       how the world, the loop and the brain fit together
│   ├── speed-gap.svg          why a ~5 Hz brain fights a 60 Hz game
│   ├── mario-decisions-agent.pdf   this README as a printable PDF
│   └── media/                 the committed clips this README plays
└── pyproject.toml             dependencies + the `mario` / `record` / `docs` extras
```

Curious how it runs with no key? `MockEnv` is a tiny hand-built platformer — gravity, variable jumps, pits, pipes, Goombas, scrolling — that exercises the whole loop offline. `MockBackend` is a crude pixel heuristic that plays the real game well enough to rehearse the timing.

Five tricks for closing the gap

The game makes 60 frames a second; the model can only answer a few times a second. These five tricks close the difference, and each one is a command-line flag:

	Trick	Flag	What it buys
A	**Bigger steps**	`--frames-per-decision N`	one answer covers N frames
B	**Ask ahead**	`--mode pipelined`	the next question is already on its way while the game keeps moving
C	**Smaller picture**	`--max-side` / `--jpeg-quality`	a smaller image means faster, cheaper answers (**never cropped**)
D	**Slow the game down**	`--fps N` / `--auto-fps`	real slow motion, so a quick reply becomes fine control
E	**Skip identical frames**	`--cache`	if the screen barely changed, repeat the last move

D can work itself out. Tell it how much lag you'll accept (`--auto-fps --stale-budget 10`) and it picks the game speed for you: a 0.25 s reply → ~40 fps, a 1 s reply → ~10 fps. Slower game, snappier agent — but a longer watch.

C never crops. It makes the picture smaller and lower quality, but never cuts anything out. Cut out the edges and you hide the Goomba — and a model that can't see the Goomba picks the wrong move. `--save-frames DIR` saves exactly what was sent, so you can check.

E saves time and money, not skill. It compares frames with a rough 16×16 fingerprint, so if the screen barely changed it can repeat the last move. `--cache-max-reuse` forces a fresh call anyway, so a frozen screen can't lock the agent in place. It's switched off for the blank-frame control, where every frame is identical and the cache would fake a perfect score.

Honest limits

Don't quote any number above without reading this.

- **World 1-1 is probably memorized.** It's the most-copied level in gaming, and the model has seen it many times. A good score here is **not** proof that it can see — knowing the level can hide bad timing.
- **Only two runs per speed, on one level.** The 15 and 30 fps pairs matching exactly is the clean part; the rest is still a small sample on a single, famous level.
- **A slow reply breaks the pattern.** One 30 fps run got a 0.49 s reply instead of 0.16 s, stalled ~9 frames per move, and stopped short at x=434. Reply times vary, and the loop is only as good as its worst reply.
- **Slow motion isn't real time.** At 15 fps the game runs 4× slower than you'd see it. Keeping up at 15–30 fps is real; at a true 60 fps the model falls behind.

Using the real model

You'll need a standard OpenAI key — the Decisions API is public beta, no waitlist. Measure first, then play:

```
export OPENAI_API_KEY=sk-...

python scripts/probe_latency.py --repeats 5   # measure the model's real reply time
python -m mda --env mario --backend live --auto-fps --cache \
    --scale 3 --record runs/live.mp4          # watch it play (and save the video)
```

Prefer it fully offline? Both commands work with `--backend mock` and no key at all.

Key flags

Flag	Meaning
`--env mock|mario`	toy platformer vs. real game
`--backend mock|live`	offline stand-in vs. the real model
`--mode blocking|pipelined`	freeze during thinking vs. overlap it
`--frames-per-decision N`	how many frames each move is held
`--fps N`	how fast the game runs in real time (`0` = as fast as possible)
`--auto-fps` / `--stale-budget`	pick the game speed from measured latency
`--control normal|blank`	run the blank-frame control
`--max-side` / `--jpeg-quality`	image budget — the main speed/cost lever
`--world` / `--rom-mode`	which level, and which sprite set (`vanilla` / `pixel` / `rectangle` / `downsample`)
`--render` / `--scale N`	show the game window, at N× size
`--record PATH` / `--record-fps`	save the run as `out.mp4` / `.gif` or a folder of PNGs
`--cache` / `--cache-threshold` / `--cache-max-reuse`	the reuse-unchanged-frames trick
`--save-frames DIR`	dump every image actually sent to the model
`--out PATH`	write a per-decision JSONL log
`--mock-latency` / `--mock-sleep`	simulate latency to rehearse timing offline

Reproduce these results

```
export OPENAI_API_KEY=sk-...                        # a live run needs your own key
python scripts/probe_latency.py --repeats 5         # expect ~0.20 s

# same sweep as the table above: step size fixed, only the game speed changes
for fps in 15 30 60; do
  python -m mda --env mario --backend live --mode pipelined \
      --fps $fps --frames-per-decision 8 --max-decisions 40 \
      --scale 3 --record runs/live_fps$fps.mp4 --no-hud
done
```

Reply times wobble, so run each speed a few times. Run the offline test suite any time with `python tests/test_pipeline.py` (17 tests, no key or network).

Cost

The Decisions API bills **input only** — $0.10 per million tokens, nothing for output. A single decision is about **500 input tokens ≈ $0.00005**, a twentieth of a cent. The whole six-run sweep above cost about **a cent**. Cost is never the bottleneck here — latency is.

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